Response to Reviewers — Paper #518

OrdinalFed: Federated Learning with Ordinal-Aware Aggregation for Diabetic Retinopathy Grading

The authors thank both reviewers for their constructive comments. Each comment is answered below; section, table and figure numbers refer to the revised manuscript.

Reviewer #2: *"... stronger experimental validation through ablation studies, additional recent baselines, independent validation data, repeated experiments, and detailed class-wise performance analysis..."*

Request	**Response**	**Where**
Ablation studies	Each component was ablated under $\alpha = 0.1$ and the real-site partition: OrdinalLoss with sample-count weights, cross-entropy with QWK weights, cross-entropy with uniform weights, and full OrdinalFed. [TBD: one-sentence finding from the ablation table]	Sec. IV-D, Table [TBD: n]
Additional baselines	A quality-aware aggregation baseline (AccWt), representative of server-side validation scoring [9], was added. It uses OrdinalFed's scoring and schedule but weights clients by accuracy instead of QWK, isolating the value of the ordinal signal. [TBD: one-sentence comparison]	Sec. IV-C, Table I
Independent validation data	All headline results are now reported on the DDR test split excluding the 50 server-set images (3,709 images), which is never used for training, aggregation or model selection; the reported round is chosen by validation QWK.	Sec. IV-D, Table I
Repeated experiments	Every configuration was repeated with [TBD: 3] random seeds and is reported as mean $\pm$ standard deviation.	Tables I–[TBD: n]
Class-wise analysis	Per-grade recall and F1 on the test split are reported for FedAvg, FedProx and OrdinalFed. [TBD: one sentence on Grades 1 and 3]	Sec. V-[TBD: x], Table [TBD: n]

Further corrections: Eqs. (4)–(6) now state the exact aggregation used in the experiments; the mechanistic analysis (Sec. V-C) was rewritten from the logged per-round server scores and aggregation weights; the server-side overhead is reported as measured ([TBD: x] s per round); the dataset statistics in Sec. IV-A were corrected.

Reviewer #3

Comment	**Response**	**Where**
1. Multiple consecutive reference format, e.g. [1-2]	Consecutive citations are given as a range (e.g. [5]–[6]), and references are numbered in order of first citation.	Sec. I, Refs.
2. Tiny font inside Figs. 1–2	Both figures were regenerated at their printed width with all text at 8 pt or larger.	Figs. 1–2
3. Description missing for Figs. 1–2	Each figure is introduced in the text with a description of what its panels, bars and lines show.	Secs. IV-B, V-B
4. IEEE citation format; DOI required	All references were verified against Crossref and arXiv and follow IEEE style with a DOI (URL and access date for the IDF Atlas). Incorrect venues, author lists, volumes and pages were corrected.	References
5. Passive voice preferred	The manuscript was revised to use the passive voice throughout.	Throughout
6. Description before all figures and tables	Every figure and table is referenced and described in the text before the float; Figs. 1–2 were moved accordingly.	Throughout